

Umax X4 LCD monitor

The X4 is a 14-inch monitor targeted towards those who want the pleasure of LCD, at as low as Rs 15,000. The price may be low, but given the average performance, opt for it only if you are hell-bent on an LCD.

Black and silver grey in colour, the panel can be tilted and swivelled. Soft touch menu buttons are on the right-hand side, but the speakers are at the last place they should be—the bottom. And this is only first step on its ladder of inadequacy.

We tested it using different slides of the DisplayMate Video Edition, and the results were mixed. In the colour and greyscale test, as well as in the streaking and ghosting test, results were good. However, in the white and black level shift test, the edges appeared



blunt: a red tinge formed due to the level-shift problem. The colour purity test didn't impress either—red appeared more like a shade of magenta, and was darker at the corners. Also, the brightness varied between the upper and lower half of the screen when we weren't sitting upright in front of it.

SPECIFICATIONS

1,024 x 768 resolution, 0.297 pixel size, 30 ms pixel response time, 2 W x 2 speakers, 42 W power consumption, weight: 4.5 Kg

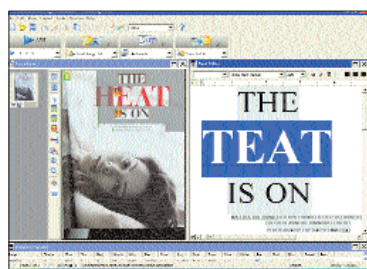
Umax X4 LCD monitor B-	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶

Price: Rs 15,500
Contacts: Neoteric Informatique
Phone: 022-24172600
E-mail: sales@neoteric-info.com
Web site: www.umax.com

Scansoft's OmniPage 14.0

At US\$ 600—Rs 26,400—OmniPage 14.0 is not worth it. First, it's too much of a hassle to get documents recognised properly. And second, it's extremely sensitive to minor scanning errors.

We used images of a variety of types to be OCR'd: a regular Word



OmniPage failed to recognise simple words such as the one in this example

document, a fax printout, a magazine page, and so on. We found that without manually setting almost everything, OmniPage got thrown off almost everywhere.

The newspaper scan was a total mess: the formatting was askew, and the text in the output was mostly junk. The magazine scan, too, was disappointing. In fact, the only document OmniPage recognised properly was the laser printout, which consisted of plain text in Courier—a fixed-width font. The software even showed up minor errors with

simple documents that contained only text in Times New Roman. Such errors are not acceptable, given that you have a choice—ABBYY FineReader, which also happens to be much cheaper.

Price: US\$ 599 (approx Rs 26,400)
Contact: HCL Infosystems
Phone: NA
E-mail: seigell@hclinsys.com
Web site: www.hclinfosystems.com

Kodak CX7300

The price of the CX7300 puts it within reach of most budget buyers. However, given the image quality, we suggest you loosen your purse strings a little bit and get a decent quality camera.

This entry-level digital camera from Kodak has a 3.2-megapixel CCD capable of generating images with a resolution of 2,096 x 1,560. It lacks optical zoom, but the 3X digital zoom helps you get close-ups. However, the zoom is practically useless, as the focus gets completely lost, and so does the colour reproduction and crispness.

We were also disappointed by the image quality of indoor photos. There was a prominent green tinge all over, and in spite of ample light in the room, the image was dark. To work around this, we set the exposure setting first to 0.5 EV, and then to 1.0 EV to get a brighter and detailed image, but there was just a marginal improvement.

Night mode yielded almost the same image quality as the 0.5 EV setting, leaving us with no other fine-tuning option. You'll have to

Price: Rs 8,700
Company: Neoteric Informatique
Tel: 022-24172600
E-mail: sales@neoteric-info.com
Web site: www.kodak.com

SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS

Intel Pentium III, Microsoft Windows 98 SE or higher, Internet Explorer 5.01 Service Pack 2, 128 MB RAM, 135 MB free hard disk space, 800 x 600 pixel colour monitor with 16-bit colour or greater video card and a compatible scanner with its own scanner driver software

Scansoft's OmniPage 14.0 C+	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Ease of user	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶



manually set a higher exposure setting to get a bright image.

However, the CX7300 returned viewable images of outdoor shoots. The image quality was much better, but when viewed at actual pixel size in Photoshop, it had red and green spots all over.

The CX7300 has an in-built memory of 16 MB, and runs on two AA batteries. You should be able to pack as much as 30 to 32 images of the 500 to 600 KB range on the internal memory.

The camera also has an SD/MMC card expansion slot—useful for those vacation photographs that might just be too much for the default memory to handle.

SPECIFICATIONS

3.2 megapixel CCD, 3X digital zoom, 16 MB internal memory, ±2 EV exposure setting, two AA batteries, 10 seconds self-timer, weight: 147 gm

Kodak CX7300 B	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶